irb is a great learning tool. It's very handy if you want to try an idea quickly and see whether it works.

Using irb

irb is run from the command line:

irb ‹*irb-options*› ‹*ruby_script*› ‹*program arguments*›

The command-line options for irb are listed in Table 6, irb command-line options, on page 278. Typically, you'll run irb with no options, but if you want to run a script and watch the step-by-step description as it runs, you can provide the name of the Ruby script and any options for that script.

Option	Description
--autocomplete, --noautocomplete	Use or don't use the autocomplete feature. The default is --autocomplete.
--back-trace-limit n	Displays backtrace information using the top *n* and last *n* entries. The default value is 16.
--colorize, --nocolorize	Use or don't use color syntax highlighting, --colorize is the default.
--context-mode n	:CONTEXT_MODE is described.
-d	Sets $DEBUG and $VERBOSE to true (same as ruby -d).
-E enc	Same as Ruby's -E option, sets internal or external encodings with in or ex.
--echo, --noecho	Echoes or doesn't echo the result of each line, the default is --echo
--echo-on-assignment, --noecho-on-assignment, truncate-echo-on-assignment	Echoes, doesn't echo, or partially echoes the result of an assignment statement. Truncated is the default.
--extra-doc-dir	Specify an extra directory for documentation.
-f	Suppresses reading ~/.irbrc.
-h, --help	Displays usage information.
-I directories	Same as Ruby's -I option, sets directories on the load path.
--inf-ruby-mode	Sets up irb to run in inf-ruby-mode under Emacs. Same as --prompt inf-ruby --nomultiline.
--inspect, --noinspect	Uses/doesn't use inspect to format output (--inspect is the default).
--multiline, --nomultiline	Use or don't use multiline editor mode. The default is multiline. (The official docs say that nomultiline is the default, but that seems not to be true in my experimentation). You can also specify modes with --singleline or --nosingleline.
--noprompt	Does not display a prompt. Same as --prompt null.
--prompt prompt-mode	Switches prompt. Predefined prompt modes are null, default, classic, simple, xmp, and inf-ruby.
--prompt-mode prompt-mode	Same as --prompt.
-r module	Requires *module*. Same as ruby -r.